infamous scuffle between Inzamam and Younis Khan during a warm-up football session. The reports – that a rivalry was brewing between the two Test greats – were complete nonsense. Even I fought with Inzi at a football session around this period – hell, everybody must have fought with everybody during football, because that's what happens when cricketing gentlemen play this aggressive but beautiful game. It was part of the warm-up culture. That we were not getting along wasn't an accurate reflection of the state of the team.

The real story at the time was about our fall and was connected to the team leadership, or the lack of it. To me, there was no leadership. Waqar Younis is a lot of things, but he's no cricket captain. With Wasim bhai also available in the side, many of us – myself included – thought Waqar was a poor choice as captain. Neither could he control the team, nor could he inspire us. The rest is history and statistics (some of our most poor showings are stemmed in this time).

The whole matter is quite complicated, so maybe I should first elaborate a bit about the infighting in the team, which had reached a crescendo. You see, the captain's hat was the real crown in 2003. Consequently, there was a war between the two Ws – Wasim and Waqar. Naturally, there were two entrenched camps. Battle lines were drawn. Both Wasim and Waqar were fighting hard for the throne. Most of the team wanted Wasim to be the captain and he did lead us for a while. But then the chairman of the PCB, Lt Gen. Tauqir Zia, sided with Waqar – there was too much politics involved. It proved to be a really bad decision. The fact that Waqar was not captain material reflected clearly in Pakistan's dismal performance on the field.

So, in a way, there were three teams within the larger Pakistan unit: the older team (Rashid Latif, Inzamam, Saeed Anwar) on one side who were in Wasim's favour; the younger team (Azhar Mahmood, Mohammad Sami, Saqlain and I) who were looking for inspiration and had decided to keep out of the power politics that the seniors were involved in but wanted Wasim to lead; and then there was the Waqar group, which had Yousuf Youhana (later christened to Mohammad Yousuf) and the likes, although they eventually crossed over to Wasim's side. The problem, operationally, was a complicated one: Waqar was empowered, officially, but the team wasn't responding to him.

There was every reason to do well with the line-up that we had. The team had a fairly large coaching unit as well. On paper, we were a strong, solid unit. Hell, we had even trained well for South Africa. But we were not united. Simple. Team politics aside, some of the senior team members were, well, getting older. I felt we gave up too easily in several matches in that World Cup because of their flagging energy or the lack of it. Literally, it felt as if they threw in the towel. Against Australia, at five wickets down, we gave up. The same thing happened versus England and India. We didn't capitalize on our strong starts and this resulted in lacklustre finishes. Simply put, we were led by men who fought like children.